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How a Y Combinator food-delivery app used TikTok to soar in the App Store



Dominic-Madori Davis — 4:00 PM PDT · July 24, 2025

The internet trend is simple: A friend or family member looks into the camera and tells viewers, in a slightly aggressive tone, that they are about to witness a presentation and that they better be nice.

That's what Kendall, the sister of Lucious McDaniel IV, did, and after she stepped aside, her brother pitched his company, [BiteSight](#), a food-delivery app that lets users watch videos of food before ordering. It also lets customers see what their friends have ordered and bookmark places to try out. The app plays on how young people engage with content — through short-form videos and recommendations from friends.

IMAGE CREDITS: BITESIGHT

McDaniel posted the video and went back to work. Fifteen minutes later, his sister texted him that their post was going viral. "We were at 20,000 views in 15 minutes," McDaniel told TechCrunch. Excitement came, but then chaos ensued as "parts of our app started to break as we got more users."

The engineering team worked around the clock to keep BiteSight functional, while McDaniel took to making TikToks about the chaos, which ended up going viral, too. He said people loved the "authenticity" behind seeing what happens when "your app explodes overnight."

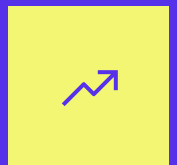
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It's called BiteSight and it's really fun I promise :)
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🎵 original sound – Lucious ~ Building BiteSight



The video of McDaniel presenting this idea has since amassed [almost 4 million likes](#) on TikTok and [a quarter of a million on Instagram](#), joining a trend of [young entrepreneurs using TikTok and Instagram Reels to gain traction and deal flow](#).

McDaniel told TechCrunch that the idea to make this video came after watching a friend partake in the same internet trend for his dating app. “It got over a million views, and he suggested I try it for BiteSight.”

Twenty-four-year-old McDaniel said he, like many young people, realized he was eating too much takeout, ordering from the same three places because he couldn't discover new restaurants on delivery apps. “I'd hit this wall of identical-looking restaurants with stock photos, and somehow every place had 4.6 stars.”

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He started keeping a spreadsheet of restaurants he'd found on Instagram and TikTok, tracking actual reviews, and seeing what his friends thought about said places. "When I realized other people were doing the exact same thing, my co-founder Zac and I decided to build something better: an app that actually reflects how we discover food today," he said, referring to Zac Schulwolf, the company's CTO.

McDaniel is no stranger to the tech industry. He previously worked at General Atlantic, where one of his main focus areas was restaurant technology. He previously founded a payments company called Phly, led product for a recruitment software, and has even angel invested in a few companies, including the fintech Mercury.

He and Schulwolf, 25, spent over a year building BiteSight, including participation in Y Combinator's Winter 2024 cohort. They then did a limited beta around New York University in April. In mid-May, the company launched an early version and did a bit of social media marketing. In June, they made their viral video.

"What made our video stand out was that what we are building resonates," said McDaniel, who is BiteSight's CEO (also known as chief eating officer). He added that "it's clear that consumers, and

especially Gen Z, are ready for something that feels fresh and built for the way they engage.”

After the video, BiteSight briefly became No. 2 in the App Store’s Food and Beverage category, bypassing Uber Eats, Starbucks, and even McDonald’s.

McDaniel said the app also gained more than 100,000 new users, and though it is only available in New York at the moment, people in other cities started messaging for a nationwide release. On the restaurant side, McDaniel said everyone from small family-owned spots to chain restaurants has reached out to partner and, of course, “we’ve had a surge of investor interest from folks who see that this is where food delivery is going.”

He declined to comment on the size of any upcoming funding deals, except to say he expects to have news to share soon.

Of course, BiteSight has a lot of big, well-funded competition like DoorDash and Uber Eats. McDaniel believes, however, that being a startup in the age of AI will be to his advantage. For example, while most of its competitors needed hundreds of engineers in their early days, BiteSight can work with AI tools that perform 10x the work of a human for much less the cost.

“By using AI to avoid massive overhead and infrastructure costs, we can do much more with much less and pass on the savings to the small business owners and customers who need it most while still maintaining healthy margins,” he said.

What also differentiates BiteSight is its focus on food and video, rather than other categories at the moment.

“We’re trying to be the go-to app for the generation

that discovers everything through social recommendations and short-form video.”

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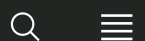
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TikTok is preparing to launch a new service that will turn its viral food videos into meals you can actually order and enjoy. The social app is partnering with [Virtual Dining Concepts](#) and Grubhub to launch “TikTok Kitchen”-branded delivery-only restaurants across the United States next year, as first reported by [Bloomberg](#). The menu at the restaurants will draw upon the most popular viral food posts on TikTok, which people can then have delivered to their door via Grubhub. TikTok plans to launch around 300 locations that will start delivering dishes in March, with plans to open more than 1,000 restaurants by the end of next year.

The initial menu will include top TikTok viral dishes like baked feta pasta, a smash burger, corn ribs and pasta chips. The baked feta, in particular, gained incredible traction in 2021 as Google reported it was the most-searched dish of the year after it gained immense popularity on TikTok. Going forward, the menu at the locations will be amended quarterly with new dishes that have started to go viral. It’s unknown whether TikTok will choose to make some popular dishes, like the baked feta pasta, permanent offerings on the menu.

TikTok confirmed to TechCrunch that creators will be receiving credit for dishes within the menu and will be featured prominently throughout the partnership.

“Proceeds from TikTok Kitchen sales will go to both support the creators who inspired the menu item and to encourage and assist other creators to express themselves on the platform in keeping with

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TikTok’s mission to inspire creativity and bring joy to its users,” TikTok said.

The company clarified, however, that this was more of a campaign to bring TikTok food to fans, and not TikTok’s venturing into the restaurant business.

That means the company likely sees this as more of a marketing effort, rather than a long-term business. TikTok didn’t say how long this “campaign” will run, or provide other details about the ordering process, or how the menu items will be selected and refreshed.

Founded in 2018, Virtual Dining Concepts runs several delivery-only ghost restaurants and has partnered with many notable individuals, including YouTube celebrity MrBeast (who runs [his own virtual restaurant business, MrBeast Burger](#)), Guy Fieri, Steve Harvey, Mariah Carey, Tyga and others. The company also has a partnership with Barstool Sports. In October, Virtual Dining Concepts [raised](#) \$20 million in Series A funding, saying it planned to use the investment to fund additional technology, enhance corporate infrastructure and provide additional marketing and customer support.

TikTok is widely known for popular food trends and is home to many viral recipes that are often reshared on other social media platforms such as Twitter, Instagram and Facebook. The short-form video app’s latest partnership indicates that the company is looking to take advantage of this popularity to raise the profile of its brand and those of its creators who are fueling the food content on its app.

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Update: The article was updated to include information about TikTok's partnership with Grubhub.

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